Sacramento STR Cleaning Business

Step-by-step gameplan (v2): Airbnb / short-term rental turnovers, restocking, inspections and residential deep cleans, with two co-owners and hired cleaners

The plan at a glance	
Owners	**You and Joyce are co-owners. Neither of you cleans.** Every clean is done by hired W-2 cleaners.
Money	Plan on **about $9,000** to start (range $6,500 to $11,000), **split with Joyce**. At 50/50 that's about $4,500 each.
Joyce	Part-time, **paid only from profit**. Handles hiring, payroll and QuickBooks, scheduling, call-outs and in-person quality checks.
Break-even	**About 7 properties** to cover all costs, including employer taxes, with neither of you paid yet. See the break-even section.
Pilot goal	**5 to 8 properties by the end of March 2027.** Go/no-go decision in **April 2027**.
Growth goal	**15+ properties by the end of 2027**, when there's real profit to split.
Hard deadline	**By January 2028** (CRNA start), the business runs without you. If UCD admits you sooner, move this up.

Ground rules

1. **CRNA comes first.** If the business ever takes time from your application, pause it or hand it fully to Joyce.
2. **Keep your share of the money separate** from your emergency fund and CRNA savings. It should be money you can lose.
3. **Get past break-even fast.** Joyce isn't paid until there's profit, so every month below about 7 properties is unpaid work for her and a risk she loses interest.
4. **The time each clean takes decides whether you profit.** Track hours per clean every week (see break-even).

Who does what

	You	Joyce
Main job	Winning clients, money and strategy	Running daily operations
Tasks	Turno bids, outreach to co-hosts and property managers, pricing, reviewing the books monthly	Hiring and training, payroll in QuickBooks, scheduling, covering call-outs with the backup cleaner, in-person spot checks
Hours/week	3 to 5 (less once you're applying)	Part-time; agree on a number in writing
Paid by	Profit share	Profit share (consider a stipend once profit passes an agreed level)

This is a suggested split. Change it with Joyce and write the final version into your partnership agreement.

Timeline

When	What happens
Nov to Dec 2026	Steps 1 and 2: confirm demand and the rules, then sign a partnership agreement
Early Jan 2027	Step 3: form the LLC, register as an employer, buy insurance and workers' comp
Jan 2027	Steps 4 and 5: hire and train the first cleaner and a backup; set up systems
Jan to Mar 2027	Steps 6 and 7: win clients and run the pilot with 5 to 8 properties
April 2027	Step 8: go/no-go decision
May to Dec 2027	Step 9: grow to 15+ properties while you apply to CRNA programs
Jan 2028	Step 10: CRNA school starts and you're investor-only

Step 1: Confirm before you spend anything

November 2026

- ☐ **Check the City of Sacramento STR rules.** A March 2026 hearing considered requiring every permitted STR to be on the owner's primary-residence lot. If it passed, focus on Roseville, Folsom, Elk Grove and rentals of 30 days or longer.
- ☐ **Agree with Joyce** on how many hours a week she'll put in, how much money each of you invests, and that both of you stay committed through 2028.
- ☐ **Talk to 10 hosts or co-hosts.** Ask what they pay now, what goes wrong, and what would make them switch.
- ☐ **Get quotes from 3 to 5 competitors** as if you were a host, and compare them with Turno's averages.
- ☐ **Both of you shadow 2 or 3 turnovers** with an experienced cleaner (pay them for the time). You'll learn what a good clean looks like and how long one takes, which you need to hire, price and do quality checks.

Step 2: Partnership agreement

November to December 2026

- ☐ **Money each of you puts in**, and whether it's returned to both of you **before** profits are split (recommended).
- ☐ **Ownership split.** If you invest equal money but Joyce does most of the work, consider whether her work earns her a larger share.
- ☐ **When Joyce starts getting paid**, for example a stipend once monthly profit passes an agreed amount.
- ☐ **Vesting for both of you over 2 to 3 years**, so someone who leaves early doesn't keep a full share.
- ☐ **Decision rights:** what Joyce decides alone, and what needs both of you (prices, spending over $X, firing staff).
- ☐ **Both of you have login access** to the bank account, QuickBooks and payroll.
- ☐ **Exit terms:** buyout if one of you wants out, and your role once CRNA school starts.
- ☐ Have a **CPA or attorney** draft or review it (about $500 to $1,000). A two-owner LLC also files a partnership tax return each year.

Step 3: Legal setup, employer registration and insurance

Early January 2027 (not December: see note)

- [ ] Form an **LLC** with the CA Secretary of State (~$70) and file the **Statement of Information** (~$20) within 90 days.
- [ ] Get an **EIN** (free), open a **business bank account**, and file a **fictitious business name** if you'll use a different name (~$50).
- [ ] Get a **City of Sacramento business tax certificate** (~$50 to $100), plus one for each other city you work in.
- [ ] Budget the **CA $800 annual LLC franchise tax**, due by the 15th day of the 4th month after you form the LLC.
- [ ] **Register with the EDD** as an employer, and set up **QuickBooks Payroll** (Joyce already knows QuickBooks).
- [ ] Buy **workers' comp before your first hire**; California requires it once you have even 1 employee.
- [ ] Buy **general liability insurance** ($1M/$2M), a **janitorial bond** and **hired and non-owned auto** coverage (cleaners drive their own cars).
- [ ] Ask your CPA whether you must **register with the CA Labor Commissioner as a janitorial employer**; if so, cleaners must also complete the required sexual-harassment-prevention training.
- [ ] **Employer paperwork:** I-9s, required workplace posters, and written policies for paid sick leave (40 hours / 5 days) and mileage reimbursement.

Timing note: if you form the LLC in December 2026, you may owe $800 for a 2026 tax year that's only a few days long, and then another $800 for 2027. Forming in early January avoids this.

Step 4: Hire and train cleaners (Joyce leads)

January 2027

- [ ] **Hire in stages:** 1 cleaner and 1 on-call backup before your first client, then a second cleaner at about 4 properties. See the staffing table.
- [ ] **Where to find cleaners:** Indeed, local Facebook groups, Craigslist, and experienced Turno or hotel housekeepers who want steady W-2 work.
- [ ] **Pay $20 to $23 an hour.** California's minimum wage is $16.90, but $20+ keeps good people. Use W-2 employees only, not 1099 contractors (California's AB5 law).
- [ ] Run a **background check** on each hire (~$30 to $50), then a **paid trial clean** that Joyce times and inspects.
- [ ] **Offer a minimum number of hours each week** where you can. Part-time cleaners with irregular hours often quit.
- [ ] **Pay drive time between jobs**, reimburse mileage at the IRS rate, and give meal and rest breaks.
- [ ] Set **target clean times** (about 1.75 hours for a 1-bedroom, 2.25 for a 2-bedroom, 3 for a 3-bedroom) and track actual times.

Step 5: Systems

January 2027

- [ ] Write a **room-by-room checklist with required photos**. Hosts care most about the photo report.
- [ ] Buy **one equipment kit per cleaner** and a starter **restock inventory**.
- [ ] Set up **Turno** (calendar sync, scheduling, marketplace) and a free **Google Business Profile**.
- [ ] Write a **service agreement**: 50% fee for same-day cancellations, late-checkout and extra-dirty charges, a damage-reporting process, a free re-clean if a guest complains, and **weekly billing to a card on file**.
- [ ] Keep a **key and access-code log**; require photos on arrival and departure.
- [ ] **Track each property as its own customer in QuickBooks** so you can see which ones make money.

Step 6: Win clients (you lead)

January to March 2027

- [ ] **Bid on jobs in the Turno marketplace**. It's the fastest way to your first clients.
- [ ] Contact **co-hosts and small property managers**. One relationship can bring 10 to 30 units.
- [ ] Join Sacramento **Airbnb/STR host Facebook groups**, BiggerPockets Sacramento and local real estate investor meetups.
- [ ] Contact **landlords who rent to travel nurses** for move-out deep cleans. Your nursing background is a selling point.
- [ ] Ask **STR-focused realtors, stagers and handymen** for referrals; pay $50 to $100 for each one that becomes a client.
- [ ] **Keep your properties in one or two areas.** Less driving between jobs means less paid drive time and mileage.
- [ ] Sell **inspections, restocking and deep cleans**. They earn more per hour than turnovers.
- [ ] **First-clean offer:** a discounted first turnover plus a free inspection. Get a Google review from every satisfied client.

Step 7: Run the pilot

January to March 2027

- [ ] Hold a **30-minute weekly check-in** and fill in the scorecard below.
- [ ] Don't let any single client exceed about **30% of revenue**, and check that host permits are in place.

Weekly scorecard

Week	Properties	Cleans	Avg hrs/clean	Call-outs	Complaints	Revenue	Costs
1							
2							
3							
4							
5							
6							

Step 8: Go/no-go decision

April 2027

- [ ] Review the scorecard together and apply the test below. Stopping early costs much less than stopping late.

Test	GO if...	STOP if...
Clients	5 or more paying properties, and they keep coming back	Fewer than 3, or clients keep leaving
Hours per clean	At or under the targets (about 2.5 paid hours for a 2-bedroom)	Over 3 hours, with no improvement
Staff	Your cleaners stay and call-outs get covered	Constant quitting or missed cleans
Quality	On-time 95% or better, no unresolved complaints	Repeated complaints
Money	Close to break-even and improving	Losing money every month with no improving trend
Your time	Under 3 to 5 hours a week	More than that, as applications approach

Step 9: Grow while you apply

May to December 2027

- [ ] **If GO:** grow to 15+ properties, hiring about 1 cleaner per 4 to 5 properties plus 1 backup.
- [ ] At about 15 properties, **promote your best cleaner to a field lead** ($2 to $3 an hour more) so they cover call-outs and do some quality checks, which takes load off Joyce.
- [ ] Add **residential deep cleans** to fill weekday gaps and slow winter months.
- [ ] Once monthly profit passes the level in your agreement, **start Joyce's stipend**.
- [ ] **If STOP:** give staff proper notice and final pay, sell the equipment, cancel insurance, and **file to cancel the LLC before the next tax year** so you don't owe another $800.

Step 10: Investor-only

January 2028 (sooner if UCD admits you)

- [ ] Review the books and scorecard **once a month**, and stay out of daily operations.
- [ ] Revisit your plan to buy bigger businesses, like laundromats, after you're working as a CRNA.

Break-even: how many properties you need

Assumes Turno's market prices, W-2 cleaners at $22 an hour, all employer taxes and workers' comp, and about 6 turnovers per property each month (60% occupancy, 3-night average stay).

One turnover (2-bedroom)

Line	Amount
Price (Turno Sacramento average)	$100
Cleaner wages: 2.5 paid hours (clean plus drive time) x $22	- $55
Employer costs, about 23%: Social Security and Medicare 7.65%, unemployment tax about 4%, workers' comp about 6%, paid sick leave about 3%	- $13
Supplies	- $5
Mileage reimbursement (about 8 miles at the IRS rate)	- $6
Card processing (about 3%)	- $3
Left to cover fixed costs	**About $18**

Fixed costs each month

Item	Per month
Insurance: liability, bond, hired and non-owned auto	$145
CA LLC franchise tax ($800 a year)	$67
QuickBooks and payroll	$115
Scheduling software and phone	$65
CPA and the partnership tax return ($1,200 to $2,000 a year)	$130
Ongoing marketing	$150
Equipment replacement	$50
Joyce's mileage for quality checks	$50
Total	**About $770**

Properties needed

Goal	Properties
Cover every cost (neither of you is paid)	**About 7**
Cover costs and **repay about $9,000 of startup money within 12 months**	About 14
Cover costs and **pay you and Joyce $1,000 a month each**	About 25 (about 20 if add-ons earn $30 per property each month)

What changes the break-even point

If...	Break-even becomes
Cleans take 3 paid hours instead of 2.5	**About 27 properties**
Occupancy is lower (5 turnovers per property each month)	About 9 properties
You pay cleaners $20 an hour instead of $22	About 5 properties
You charge $110 instead of $100 (once you have reviews)	About 5 properties

Bottom line: about 7 properties covers costs, about 14 also repays your startup money in a year, and about 20 to 25 starts paying you both. **The time each clean takes matters most.** Half an hour of extra time per clean nearly erases the profit. Control it with the checklist, target times, clustered properties, and a price increase once you have reviews.

Your share of the profit is taxed on your personal returns. Set aside about 25 to 35% of what you take out for income and self-employment taxes, and have your CPA confirm the right amount.

Startup budget (with employees from day 1)

Item	Estimated cost
LLC, Statement of Information, city business tax certificate, fictitious business name filing	$200 to $250
CA LLC franchise tax (first year)	$800
Liability insurance, bond, hired and non-owned auto (down payments)	$400 to $700
Workers' comp deposit	$400 to $800
QuickBooks and payroll setup (first 2 months)	$200 to $300
2 equipment kits	$1,200 to $2,000
Restock inventory	$200 to $300
Background checks and paid trial cleans (3 hires)	$400 to $700
Google Business Profile, simple website, logo	$0 to $300
Launch marketing	$300 to $500
CPA/attorney for the partnership agreement	$500 to $1,000
Wage buffer: 2 to 4 weeks of payroll before client payments come in	$2,000 to $3,000
Possible CA Labor Commissioner janitorial registration (ask your CPA)	$0 to $500
Total (plan on about $9,000; about $4,500 each at 50/50)	**About $6,500 to $11,000**

How many cleaners to hire

Properties	Turnovers/mo	Paid hours/mo	Staff
1 to 4	6 to 24	15 to 60	1 part-time cleaner + 1 on-call backup
5 to 8	30 to 48	75 to 120	2 part-time cleaners + 1 on-call backup
10 to 15	60 to 90	150 to 225	3 to 4 cleaners + 1 backup
15 to 25	90 to 150	225 to 375	4 to 6 cleaners, including a field lead, + 1 backup

Rule of thumb: about 1 cleaner per 4 to 5 properties, plus 1 backup. One cleaner can do about 2 turnovers between an 11am checkout and a 3 to 4pm check-in, so hire for busy days (Sundays, holidays), not the monthly average. Since neither owner cleans, **never operate without a backup**.

Pricing

Service	Price	Basis
1-bedroom turnover	$70 to $75	Turno Sacramento average
2-bedroom turnover	$100 to $105	Turno Sacramento average
3-bedroom turnover	$140 to $145	Turno Sacramento average
Inspection between stays (photo report, damage notes)	$35 to $60	Estimate
Restocking	Cost plus 15 to 20%	Estimate
Residential deep clean (3-bedroom)	$275 to $450	Estimate; confirm with competitor quotes

Market snapshot

Measure	Estimate
Active STR permits, City of Sacramento (July 2026, reported secondhand)	About 511
Listings, City of Sacramento (varies by tracker)	About 600 to 1,100
Listings, Sacramento, Roseville and Folsom combined	About 7,800
Peak season	June to October, plus the State Fair, graduations, Aftershock and holidays
Competitors	Mostly solo cleaners on Turno and general house cleaners; few dedicated STR companies

Risks to watch

- ☐ **Cleans take longer than planned.** This is the biggest threat to profit. Track hours per clean every week.
- ☐ **Joyce burns out working unpaid.** Reach break-even fast and agree in writing when her stipend starts.
- ☐ **Cleaners quit or call out.** Always have a backup, pay above minimum wage, and offer steady hours.
- ☐ **City STR rules shrink the market.** Target the wider metro area and rentals of 30 days or longer.
- ☐ **One bad clean costs a client.** Use photo checklists, Joyce's spot checks and a free re-clean guarantee.
- ☐ **Payroll goes out before clients pay.** Bill weekly to a card on file and keep the wage buffer.
- ☐ **Taking time from your CRNA application.** Use the April go/no-go test and the rule that CRNA comes first.

All figures are estimates as of November 2026 and are not legal, tax or financial advice. Confirm the legal, tax, payroll and insurance items with a CPA or attorney, and confirm STR rules with the City of Sacramento. Market and price figures come from Turno, AirROI, GuestFavorites and Airbtics.